

You said it...



It's good to see the Slackware Linux and OpenOffice 3 CD/DVD with the October issue. Thanks for it.

I read the feedback from fellow reader Hartmut in the 'You Said It' section about the lack of hardware support in Linux. First of all, I would like to share my experience on Linux...

A few months back while downloading Debian Lenny on my new Dell Inspiron 1525 laptop (unfortunately, on Windows Vista), I thought of having an alternate Internet connection using my Nokia 3220 (which is pretty old!) phone. I downloaded the Nokia PC suite for Windows, purchased the data cable for less than 200 rupees (surely it wasn't Nokia's) and thought it would work. But alas... the Nokia Suite (running on Windows) didn't recognise my phone even after installing the phone's cable driver, and this was only because of the cheap cable. This forced me to drop my plans as purchasing a branded data cable would have cost me more than Rs 500 (at least).

So I installed Debian Lenny and tried to connect (using the same phone and the cheap cable) to the Internet using the wvdial method, which is also mentioned in the October issue's Q&A section. Wow! It not only recognised the phone's modem, it worked very smoothly (out-of-the-box) and I didn't need to replace the cable either. It saved me from having to spend extra money too.

As far as printers are concerned, I have used HP 3550 and 656c, which are older models and they too worked well on Linux (again, out-of-the-box), while on Windows, I've had to search for the Vista drivers for these models to work (which I didn't even try to do).

So, from my point of view, I don't think that there is lack of hardware support in Linux. Instead, maybe there is lack of 'easy' support because we have to do a lot of research/googling to find out what the problem is before getting the solution. But being a Linuxer, that's part of the fun, right?

I don't deny that there might be some problem with the Epson printer/scanner Hartmut is using, but the Linux community support is so strong that the solution will be out soon. And at least, it's not that kind of 'proprietary' support where you have to send chains of e-mails or select a number of options just to explain, "The driver is not supported; could you please provide a new driver," and finally get a response like, "Sorry sir, we don't support this model anymore!"

—Anant Vyas, anant.vyas23@gmail.com



I write this mail regarding feedback on the Epson printer not working on Mandriva 2009.1. Let me share a story with you. I bought my HP Photosmart D5368 printer in April this year. It has a host of non-standard printing features, including printing directly onto CDs and DVDs, plus automating paper type detection and verification (if I select plain paper as the paper type but feed in photo paper, it will not print). And, it connects via USB. My computer is also self-made, with an ASUS M2N-CM DVI MoBo and a 2.3 GHz triple-core AMD Phenom processor.

The printer came with two CDs—one with drivers for Windows and Mac, and another with CD label printing software, for Windows only. At that time, I was using Windows XP Media Centre Edition 2005 SP3, and Ubuntu 9.04 Jaunty Jackpote.

I unpacked my printer, plugged it in, switched on my PC, booted Ubuntu and printed. A perfect test page came out. I even verified that CD printing worked. Cut to Windows XP; I went through the two CDs, and then went through a series of IRQ conflicts, reconnected cables at least a dozen times and installed a second device node for my printer before I could print.

I believe your problem lies with the I/O controller on your motherboard, which manages the USB ports. Either that's faulty, or the standard USB drivers don't work properly with it.

For the future, I would also suggest

you switch your printer to an HP model. When I purchased mine, Canon Pixmas, with better quality at half the price, were available. I stuck with HP because of the HPLIP (Hewlett Packard Linux Imaging Project) where HP developers work to make open source drivers available for Linux and BSD. This is probably the only instance where the device manufacturer works on fully free open sourced drivers, which support the full functionality (not merely the 'just works' bit).

—Boudhayan Gupta, bg13.ina@gmail.com



This long drawn-out discussion seems to be related to just a single specific problem. I use Ubuntu on a Compaq Pentium 4 (2004 model) desktop and bought an Epson Stylus CX2800 (USB printer-cum-scanner) in 2007 on the assurance from an Epson sales executive that it would work in both Windows and Linux, and that the company's trained technician would install it on both. The 'trained' technician who came, however, did not know what Linux was and made a mess of installing it even on Windows. I had to uninstall and reinstall it in Windows, by following the instructions from the installation CD. For Linux I had to turn to the Internet.

Epson mentions only the Windows operating system in its requirements, and gave only Windows drivers and installation files in the CD. However, it has an associate (www.avasys.jp) that develops and maintains a repository of Linux drivers/installation files for various models of printers, scanners and MFDs. We have to download it from the associate's site. The procedures given are lengthy CLI steps. I succeeded in installing the printer, but it performed only a few of the functionalities compared to its performance on Windows. But then I could swiftly install the printer with complete functionality from the Ubuntu GUI using the driver for model number CX3800, which is built into Ubuntu. I could not install the scanner, and had to